



Caritas Versus Cupiditas in John Keats' "Bright Star"

John Keats' "Bright Star" has become one of the hallmarks of romantic English literature with its beautiful metaphors and hyperbolized descriptions of love. Within the poem, Keats uses both religious and sexually evocative images and metaphors to further the reader's understanding of the speaker and the woman's romantic relationship. Throughout "Bright Star", the speaker of the poem is constantly placing these competing images of love to illustrate their relationship. Keats first uses those associated metaphors to show religious love as a form of *caritas*, a Latin word defined as perfect and pure love with deep Christian significance (*Caritas* 1). He then uses the sexually evocative images and metaphors to show *cupiditas*, a Latin term for carnal and sensual love (*Cupiditas* 1). Within John Keats' "Bright Star", Keats shows, through the combination of religious imagery and evocative imagery, the ideal form of a romantic relationship, a combination of both *caritas* and *cupiditas*.

Throughout "Bright Star", one of the first references that the speaker of the poem uses to describe his female love is her "eternal lids" (Keats 4). This is the first example of religious imagery being used to describe their relationship and each other. In comparing the female to a concept of eternity, the speaker points to the lasting nature of their relationship. Secondly, the speaker of the poem explains the nature of the relationship as a "priestlike task", showing the

solemn and pure nature of their relationship (Keats 6). Their relationship is to be respected and revered as a priest is commonly treated. Finally, the speaker shows his devotion to his partner when he mentions that he wishes he was “steadfast as thou art” in reference to the woman (Keats 2). As opposed to the carnal descriptions of love and lust often portrayed in poetry, the speaker of the poem is pointing to the constant and fixed nature of the woman. The speaker, by referring to the woman as steadfast, is elevating her above her base human nature and making her appear more heavenly.

In using religious imagery in connection to the speaker and the woman’s relationship, the speaker of the poem helps to elevate the romantic relationship from a base animalistic level to something more pure. This makes the romantic relationship seem more holy than might be assumed in their budding romantic relationship and harkens to the *caritas* form of their love. Keats here is first showing that to have a true romantic relationship that the individuals must both first strive for their relationship to be holy. Yousef Bakhshizadeh Gashti, from the *Kashmir Journal of Language Research*, echoes this belief of Keats when he states, “In Keat’s view, love is a religion, and this suggests that there exists a sense of worship in love. This metaphor implies that love must be as pure as religion and that there must not be any imperfection in this holy love, and for preserving this sacredness, a lover should be martyred” (Gashti 95). This is the essence of a *caritas* form of love. Not only is the love elevating and higher, through the descriptions of the speaker and the woman’s relationship in “Bright Star”, readers are able to feel a level of religious devotion between the two lovers, essential to a *caritas* form of love.

In direct contrast with the religious imagery used to describe the speaker and the woman’s relationship at the beginning of the poem is the evocative and lust-based imagery used at the end of the poem. This is first shown when the speaker of the poem says that he is “pillow’d

upon [his] fair love's ripening breast" indicating that the speaker of the poem and the woman have a close romantic relationship (Keats 11). As opposed to the higher and elevated metaphors used to describe their love before, the new hallmark of the speaker and the woman's relationship is the physical intimacy they have at night. To reaffirm this change in their relationship, the speaker later mentions being able to "hear her tender-taken breath" to indicate the nights that the couple has been sleeping together (Keats 14). These images paint a different picture of their relationship than the religious imagery used previously at the beginning of the poem and start to transition their romantic relationship into something more carnal than heavenly.

It is at this ending of the poem that Keats turns to cupiditas as the driving force of love in their romantic relationship. As opposed to the pure and elevated relationship from the beginning of the poem, the evocative imagery at the end of the poem makes the relationship feel more carnal and lust-driven. It is no longer the "priestlike" and "eternal" relationship from the beginning of the poem, but their relationship is now determined and shown to the readers of "Bright Star" primarily by their physical intimacy (Keats 4,6).

Shafqat Hussain, from the University of Sindh, shows this other side of Keats' poem of love when he states, "Keats comes as a sensational poetic genius. The poetic mind of Keats is engulfed in sensuality. He is more like a sensual poet than a contemplative poet. Sensuousness is at the heart of Keats' poems. Keats' senses of impressions are rapid and acute, although he has a special knack for expressing them through solid auditory imagery. Keats expressed the glory of objects, the majesty of the cosmos from the heavens to the wildflowers of the forests, through these sense impressions. Keats' graphic sense is full of beautiful detail as well as being provocative. Every word and verse are brimming with sensual beauty" (Hussain 121). Hussain is proving here the sensual and cupiditas nature of "Bright Star". Keats uses detailed metaphors and

images about the romantic relationship to show the depth of the speaker of the poem and the woman's romantic relationship. Through the images of the speaker lying on his partner's chest and sleeping with her, the speaker of the poem takes the relationship from an elevated level to an altogether earthly and very mortal relationship. These sensual moments make the love described in the poem feel more like cupiditas than previously shown.

Both the religious imagery and the evocative imagery combine in "Bright Star" within the overarching metaphor of the Bright Star. At the beginning of the poem, the Bright Star is referring to a guiding light in the heavens for the speaker of the poem. To hearken to the themes of religious imagery, the Bright Star is referenced as being "hung aloft in the night" to symbolize the elevated separation that the star has from the earthly world (Keats 3). The star is also said to be "watching" and "gazing" upon the differing elements of nature, indicating again the separation between the heavens and the earth (Keats 4, 8).

The speaker of the poem is referring, through this metaphor of the Bright Star, to the nature of his and the woman's heavenly relationship. Like the Bright Star has a separation from the world, the speaker and the woman's relationship is so pure that it is separated from the carnal ways of the world. Their relationship is not to be considered as temporary or mortal; it is instead the "hung aloft" example of what pure love can and should be (Keats 3).

However, the Bright Star referenced in the poem changes from a description of a heavenly luminary to an earthly relationship at the end of the poem. The change of the Bright Star is shown when the speaker of the poem, after being asked if the Bright Star represents his relationship, states, "No—yet still stedfast, still unchangeable, Pillowed upon my fair love's ripening breast" to show that the speaker of the poem is changing the bright star now to representing his close romantic relationship with the woman (Keats 10-11). The Bright Star is no

longer a large and impersonal object staring down from the heavens but a very real and very earthly relationship. This also seems to change the love again from *caritas* to *cupiditas*.

It is at this change of the Bright Star from a heavenly body to an earthly relationship that the full combination of *caritas* and *cupiditas* occurs. The speaker goes on to mention that they are “still stedfast” and “still unchangeable” to show that while they have an earthly and carnal relationship, that the speaker and the woman’s relationship is still reflecting the heavenly notions that the Bright Star embodied at the beginning of the poem (Keats 10). The reader of the poem is now forced to compile both the metaphors and images of religious and evocative nature through the overarching metaphor of the Bright Star and its duality of meaning.

These competing uses of religious and evocative images used throughout “Bright Star” combine to paint the majestic and complete form of love that Keats is hoping to portray within the poem. This is further shown through the speaker of the poem’s comparisons to the nature of their relation as the purity of “snow upon the mountains”, and that it is “stedfast still unchangeable” to hearken both to their *caritas* and *cupiditas* form of love (Keats 9,10). This combination of the competing images also helps to provide a powerful tension between *caritas* and *cupiditas* in the couple’s relationship and helps their relationship to be fully and deeply expressed.

Through Keat’s metaphors and images of both *caritas* and *cupiditas*, he locks the reader alongside the speaker of the poem and his partner in balancing both carnal and pure relationships to be “Awake forever in a sweet unrest” (Keats 13). These metaphors combine both their *caritas* relationship and their *cupiditas* relationship, through the use of the Bright Star, into a whole and complete form of love, which may be the tribute the speaker of the poem is striving to give to humanity at large.

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